had bought vast tracts of land for this. All this went to dogs after Kurien was dragged in for questioning in the spy case.

With the business venture with Kurien as a backup, I upped my ante in ISRO. In July 1993, a couple of months before the first launch of PSLV, I told Rao that I wanted to quit if there was no clear succession plan for LPSC, of which I was the deputy director. The logical progression of a deputy director was to become an associate director before taking over as the director.

Rao, who was on an extension as the ISRO chief, was to retire the next year. With Gowarikar having moved out of ISRO to become the secretary, science and technology, soon after Rao took over as the ISRO chairman, the contenders for the chairman post were R M Vasagam, Muthunayagam, both engineers, and R Kasturirangan, an astrophysicist. In terms of qualification and seniority, Vasagam would have been the natural choice for the post, but he was seen as too soft a person to captain the ISRO ship through the rough sea of challenges the organisation faced from within and outside.

Still I believe Vasagam, like Y Janaradhana Rao, was one of the chairmen ISRO never had. Vasagam could well be considered the father of APPLE (Ariane Passenger Payload Experiment). When the French offered a free ride for the first India-made satellite onboard its flight of the Ariane rocket using Viking engines on 16 July 1981, Vasagam was so sure about the satellite's success that he asked government agencies including Defence and Doordarshan to give their requirements so that the transponder could be programmed accordingly.

It appeared that nobody shared Vasagam's enthusiasm or confidence and the response was poor. Finally, ISRO had to make some videos of tribal dances to be telecast during the gaps between education programmes given by some agencies. Finally, when the satellite remained in orbit for its mission life of two years, though one of the solar panels failed to deploy, there were no Doordarshan programmes to be aired.

Vasagam was called, in VSSC, an 'encyclopedia of rockets', but he never projected himself. He could speak endlessly, with the minutest of details of virtually every rocket man had made. Probably the only person